The Hidden Curriculum of the Econ Job Market

by *Javier Gonzalez*[*] — (website) — (latest version) — 2025-12-19

Despite the abundance of guides, webinars, and official resources, I found that much of the advice available was shaped by pre-COVID experiences or tailored to candidates from top-ranked institutions. These "hidden curriculum" elements include not just the logistics of applications and interviews, but also the subtle expectations, networking strategies, and unspoken norms that can make a significant difference in outcomes. My goal here is to complement the current advice with the experience of a candidate from a lower-ranked school.

Take the advice in this document with a grain of salt, as this is my personal experience on the job market in the 2025-26 cycle as a Ph.D. Economics Candidate from Southern Methodist University.

I found the following resources particularly helpful:

- *A Guide and Advice for economists on the U.S. Junior Academic Job Market 2018-2019* by John Cawley (outdated but with usefull information)
- AEA Prep. Job Market Resources
- AEA JOE Committee on the Job Market videos and documents
- EJM Informational discussions and webinars
- European Job Market for Economists (EJME) with Guides for Candidates and workshops

Housekeeping

The advice in the *Advice* sections are in no particular order.

I will skip the *offer bargaining* stage as I don't think I can add to the discussion. Please refer John Cawley's guide and always seek advice from your advisor.

The examples of how I structured my answers will be around a *quote* block, so you can easily identify them, like the following

> *My future research will be dedicated to expanding this methodological pipeline ...*
>
> — *Javier Gonzalez*

[*] Thanks to Fernanda Da Silva for encouranging me to write down these tips so that other SMU students can get more context while navigating the job market. This document also served me as a personal journal to reflect on my own experience and keep my sanity.

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Preparing Applications

Your Job Market Paper should be finished by August before the market. This means a *polished* draft with all pieces, figures, and tables. You will have zero time to work on your JMP from September to December when you are sending applications. In my case, I just had my firstborn daughter in September, which served as a good commitment device to have everything in order before her arrival.

Your network and your advisor's network is key to get interviews. This is the time to use the network you have been building during your academic career. Reach out to MA advisor or back-home professors that are willing to help you. Make sure your advisor is willing to reach out to their network on your behalf on the places you want to go. Ask for the letters at least 1 month before the closest application deadlines.

Practice your JMP talk often and well before the market: repeated rehearsal helps you anticipate common questions (in my case, my JMP raises concerns about reverse causality, which I address this on slide 2), develop concise answers, and project confidence during interviews and fly-outs. Get practice by presenting at workshops, brownbags, student seminars, conferences, and by running your talk by seminar speakers, peers, and advisors.

Expand your network strategically by connecting with people who work in the markets you target. Attend major regional conferences and workshops to build relationships with faculty and researchers who can later vouch for you or forward your CV to hiring committees. These contacts often help by sending informal emails or making introductions that make a real difference in getting noticed. For example, if you want to target the Spanish market, prioritize attending the Simposio de la Asociación Española de Economía (AEE) and use that opportunity to meet potential connections in person.

Create your academic website early. Use a ready-made template and host it on GitHub Pages to save time and avoid reinventing the wheel. Follow the academicpages guide to get a clean, professional site up quickly. Use an LLM to draft and update content so you do not need to know HTML. Prominently display the essentials: CV, Job Market Paper, a one-paragraph research summary, and clear contact information. Keep navigation and filenames obvious, make the site mobile-friendly, and ensure the key documents are one click away. Hiring committees skim hundreds of applications, and small frictions can make them stop.

Applications

A typical application package includes:

1. Cover letter
2. Curriculum Vitae
3. Job Market Paper
4. Research Statement*
5. Teaching Statement*
6. Letters of Recommendation (usually 3)

** I noticed a shift that most non-US positions do not require Research or Teaching Statements. But in some sense these topics will come up in the interviews, so there is value in writting them.*

There is plenty of advice on how to prepare each of these documents, so I will not go into them here.

Strategy

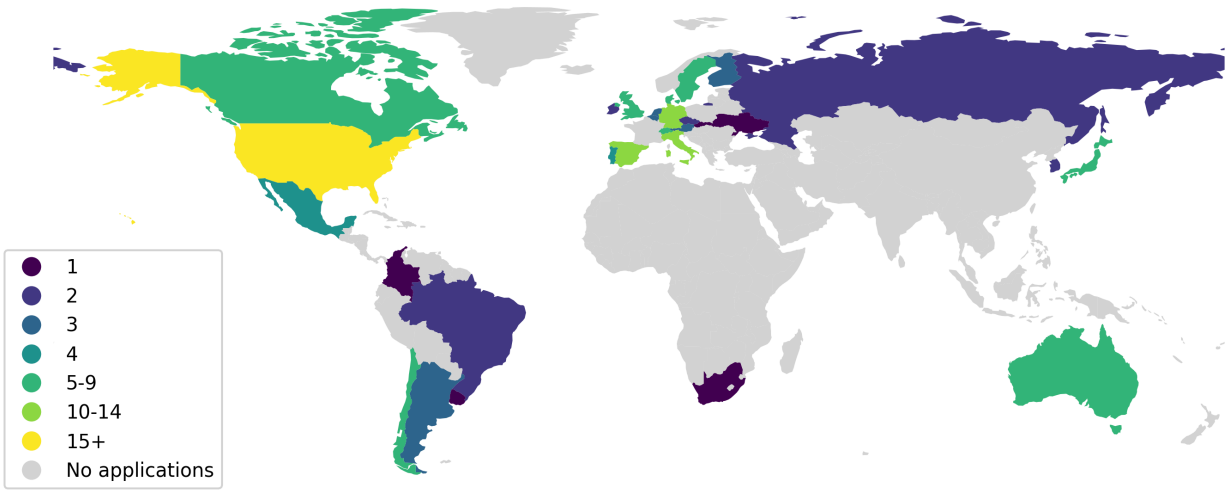
I applied to 272 positions in total. With 198 (69.4%) for Assitant Professor (AP), 44 (16.1%) for Postdocs, and the rest a mixture of Lecturer and Industry positions.

My main strategy was to apply broadly. Evidence that the academic economics job market is contracting (see Econ-Jobs.com and John List's post) suggested fewer and less predictable openings, so casting a wide net increased my chances of getting noticed. Even when a position did not appear to be a perfect fit (for example, a finance department instead of economics), I still applied and let the committee decide if I was a good match. Many departments prefer to hire an outstanding candidate even if the precise subfield differs.

Figure 1 shows the geographical distributions of applications I sent. I sent 140 applications to institutions in the U.S. + LATAM (51.5%) , 111 (40.8%) to Europe, 13 to Asia (predominatly Japan), 7 to Australia, and 1 to South Africa. I purposely avoided applying to add in China and the Middle East.

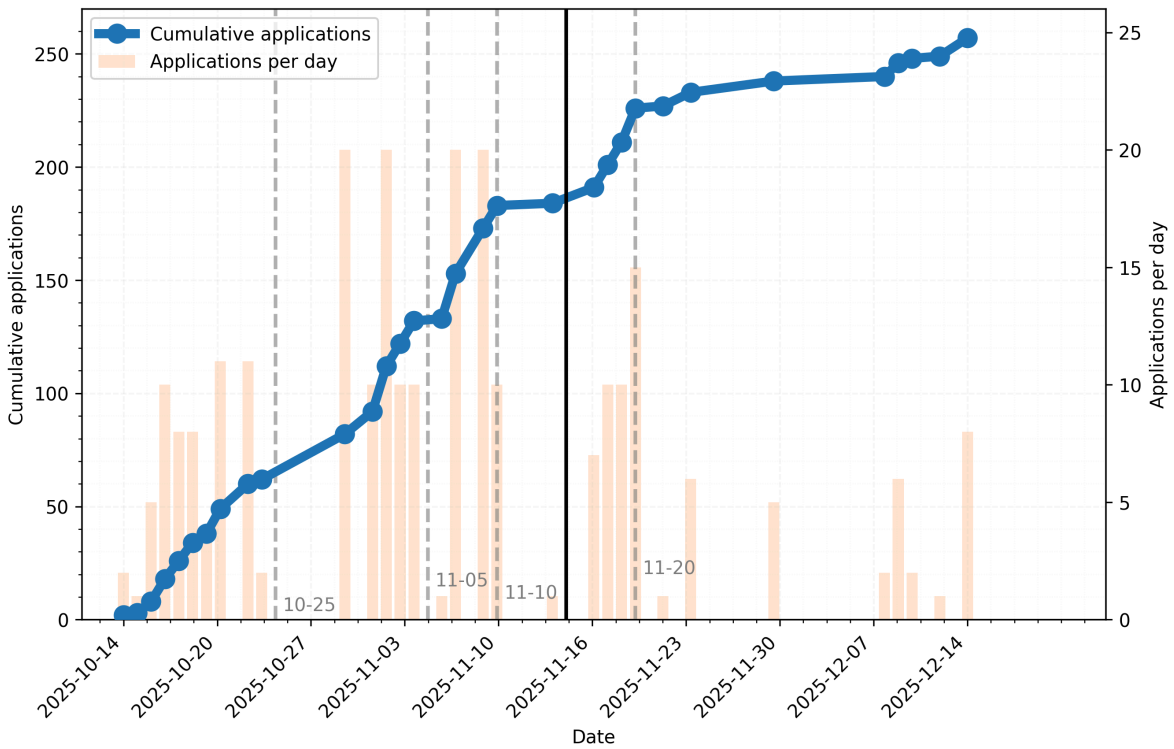
Figure 2, shows the timeline of my applications. I started to work on application materials in early September and sent my first batch of applications by mid-October. The most important deadline for applications is November 15 (solid black line), as many departments have this as their target deadline.[2] I also set up my own target deadlines (grey vertical lines) to have batches of applications ready. The

Figure 1: Geographical distribution of my applications



[2]This is because most departments in the U.S. go over applications in Thanksgiving break, and will have interviews by mid-December.

Figure 2: Application Timeline



Notes: The grey vertical lines represent the target deadlines that I sent myself to have a batch of apps ready. The most important deadline is November 15 represented by the solid black line.

idea is that you target 2-5 days before the advertized target deadline just have some leeway in case of technicals issues in the application procedures.

Applications take time. Figure 2 also shows the number of applications I sent each day. You can see that I had days with 10+ applications sent, these were mostly 8 hours of applications with around 10 applications only using the AEA JOE or EJM platforms.[3] However, some institutions also require you to send the application through their own platform, which can be time consuming as you need to re-upload all documents and fill in personal information again. Create a LinkedIn profile! This will make it easier to autofill some of the personal information required in some of these platforms.

Set-up

I used `vscode` that both generated documents using `python` and allowed me to modify the documents with `typst`. You can think of `typst` as a LaTeX replacement with modern syntax and instant preview (no need to compile the `.typ` file everytime you want to see a change).

My set up can be devided into 3 main components:

1. Gather info about job add, department, and school/project if it is a post doc
   - This can be time consuming as you might want to read faculty pages, so take it into consideration
2. Let a LLM read the addition information + CV to create a single paragraph to be at the end of the Cover letter to indicate fit with the position
3. Use `typst` to modify the cover letter template
   - Make sure you get the position + institution right
   - add personal reasons to apply to that position
   - Modify the LLM generated paragraph to make it more personal

[3] These platforms make the application process easier as you can upload all your documents once and then just select them for each application.

If you want to see my full set-up please check this repo, in particular the `personalize_docs.ipynb` notebook.

Keep a `.txt` file with all the extra information you will always copy and paste. In this repo the file is `other_docs/other_info.txt`.

Advice

In your cover letter always emphasize the fit with the postion, meaning you need to tailor them to each position. Personal reason here are very important. Do not be afraid to **bold** the key phrases that you want the committee to remember about you. Examples:

> *As a Spanish national, my family and I are eager to **return to Europe** so our newborn daughter can grow up immersed in European culture. We are seeking a community with a safe learning environment, a key factor in our decision to **leave the United States**.*

> *My wife, who is Mexican, and I, a Chilean citizen, are eager to **return to our roots in Latin America**. We want our newborn daughter to grow up immersed in the culture, and our search for a safe learning environment for her is the primary motivation for our move from the United States.*

> *My family and I are eager to **leave the United States**. We want our newborn daughter to grow up in a different cultural environment and are seeking a community with a safe learning environment. We are also **willing to learn Japanese** as soon as possible to better integrate into the local culture and academic community*

You do not need to over-tailor your Teaching or Research statements. Many non-U.S. positions, most do not even request them and, when they are submitted, committees often give them only cursory attention. I personalized mine, but in practice hiring decisions tend to hinge more on the Job Market Paper and your interview performance, where these topics will surface naturally.

Use your **signals**. Remember that you have 2 signals for the AEA JOE and 10 signal for the EJME. The common advice here is that you send a signal where your committee does not know anyone AND that you think there is a chance they will hire you In other words, do not waste your signals in MIT, Harvard, Chicago, or top in EU However, I don't know if they did anything for me. No institutions I sent my signals to invited me to interview, which is either I send the wrong signals or they don't care that much about them. That said, David Schindler has stated that European institutions do pay attention to signals.

On the EJM you can link a 1-minute JMP spiel; I uploaded one and it received about 60 views (roughly 40 from the EJM platform). That exposure generated some engagement and the exercise forced me to refine and rehearse a concise 1-minute presentation, which is valuable practice for interviews.[4]

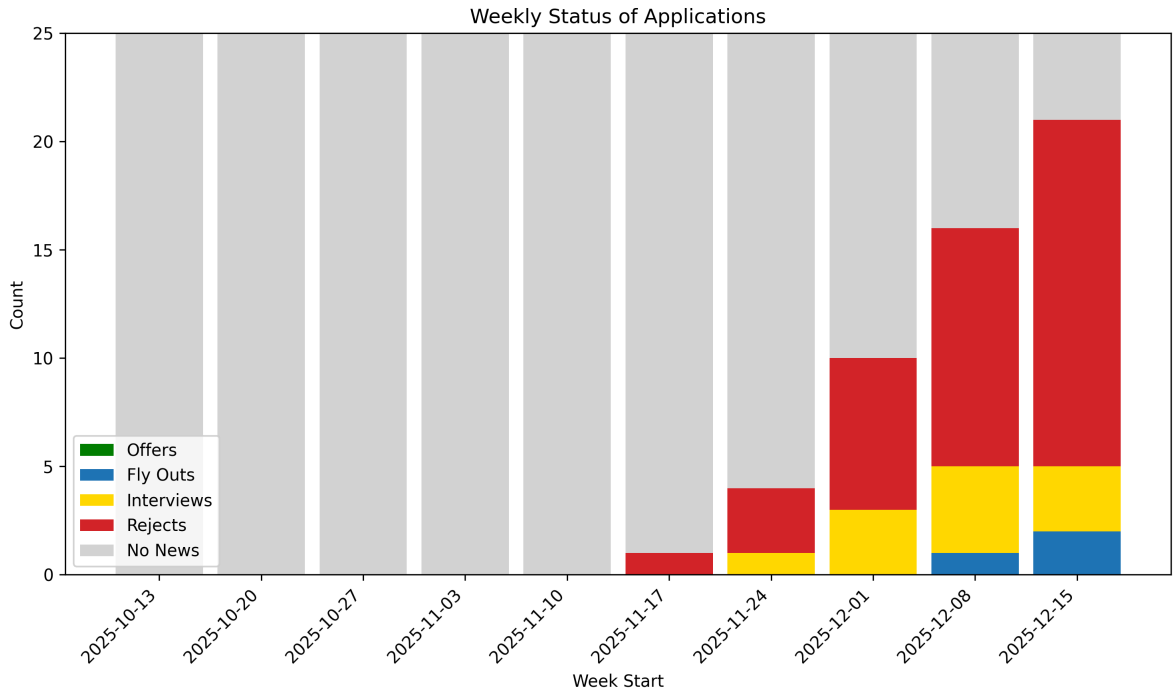
Waiting

Resist the urge to check EconJobRumors! You might cave once, but anonymous posts cannot be verified, and small rumours often spiral out of control, amplifying anxiety among candidates. Focus instead on reliable sources and your own preparations.

Econtrack can be a useful aggregator for AEA JOE listings, but it is incomplete and sometimes unreliable because any user can change a job's status. Do not treat its updates as definitive unless an entry is explicitly "verified by an official of this institution". Use Econtrack for convenience, but keep your own

[4] A viewer appreciated that the video connected to my AI methodology.

Figure 3: Weekly Status



Notes: The count limit is set to 25 to emphasize the small activity/updates received. The total number of applications is 250+.

tracker with links and timestamps and confirm key updates from institutional sources before acting on them.

In my experience the EJM status updates tend to be relatively reliable and can give you a useful signal about where a search stands. For example, when a job shows "Interview scheduling completed" status it usually means the committee has moved to arranging interviews; if you see that status and have not received an invitation, there is a high probability you did not make the cut. Conversely, a visible "Scheduling interviews" without an invitation is likewise a strong signal you did not make the cut.

That said, platforms vary and not every position uses EJM for scheduling or status updates. Some postings remain in "Reviewing applications" for long periods, and does not necessarily imply imminent they will send interview invites soon. As an example, i received a postdoc interview invite from an institution whose EJM status remained in "Reviewing applications" until January. Because of these differences, the most reliable information is to ask if your advisor if they have a **close connection** in the institution and is willing to ask around.

I started to recieve rejections in mid-November as you can see in Figure 3. Most positions will not give you any news. So if you get to mid-December and the application target deadline has long passed, it is likely that you did not make it to the interview stage. In my case, 92% of all my applications did not receive any updates.

What is you don't hear anything after mid-December? In the 2025-26 cycle, the European Job Market for Economists (EJME) urged departments to conduct virtual interviews between December 15 and December 18. The AEA JOE Committee recommended that interviews should be held after December 3, when the signal went out. Therefore, it is likely you did not make it to the interview stage in this first round. This does not mean that you are doomed!

There are 3 reasons why you can still have a chance. First, the timeline is a little different for postdoc positions. Some might want to wait for the AP positions to finish their matching, so they can pick from the remaining candidates. They have the incentive to do this since in general an offer from a AP position is more attractive than a postdoc. Second, some institutions also more later in the market. These departments have a similar incentive as postdocs, since an offer from a higher ranked institution

is more attractive. Third, there is a market scramble where unmatched institutions and candidates can find each other in March. Remember that you need to register to participate in the scramble so be on the lookout for the registration dates.[5]

[5] For the year 2025, the registration for both institutions and candidates was March 6-12.

Interviews

I got my first interview invite at the end of November for an Assistant Professor (AP) position in LATAM. By December 12 I have received 5 interview invites (2 AP, 2 Postdoc, 1 Consulting). That means that only 5 out of my 272 applications (1.8%) resulted in an interview.[6] Almost all of my interviews virtually in December before the holiday break (before December 18th).

Common Structure

Assistant professor: ($n = 2$)

1. Talk about yout JMP (10mins)
2. Research Agenda (10mins)
3. Teaching Philosophy (5mins)
4. Why our department? (5mins)

Postdocs: ($n = 2$)

1. Talk about yout JMP (10mins)
2. Research Agenda in relations to project (5mins)
3. What skill can you bring to the proposed projects (10mins)
4. Why our project? (5mins)

Industry interviewsvary quite a lot depending on the firm (e.g. consulting or data-scince). Mohsen Foroughifar put it best when talking about the Marketing Academic Job in his LinkedIn post.

In my experience interviewing with Analysis Group, they focused more on econometric techniques and on how I defended them than I had expected; in other words, they were stricter about technical skills than I anticipated. My first-round interview followed this structure:

1. Talk about yout JMP (15mins)
2. Explain Econ concept to a jury/judge (5mins)
3. What do you like more about the research work? (5mins)
4. Do you have any questions for us? (5mins)

Advice

Treat the interview as a conversation. Where you need to walk the fine line of having a perfect Job Market spiel combined with the flexibility to answer questions and adapt to the interviewers' interests. Although standard advice recommends having 1-, 5-, and 10-minute versions of your JMP (the "onion" idea), I have found a clear 3–4 minute spiel works best for most interviews. It is short enough to hold attention yet long enough to convey the core contribution, identification, and main results. Practice this version until you can adjust depth on the fly depending on the audience, because interviewers will often interrupt with questions. Answer briefly, then steer them back to the main points you still want to make. Above all, sound genuinely excited about your research and about joining the department or postdoc project, and use concise, practiced phrases to highlight why your work and fit matter.

Always start your JMP spiel with a version of the following:

> *I am an* `MAIN_FIELD` *economist, working in the intersection of* `SECOND_FIELD` *and* `THIRD_FIELD`*. My JMP ...*

This helps the committee to place you within the field, and understand better your work.

[6] This is way bellow the rate reported by McFall et. al. (2015) where thye find people interview for 10-20% of the positions they apply to. However, their 80% of their sample comes from a top 50 institutions, pre-COVID times, and with a booming academic job market.

> *I am an Applied economist, working in the intersection of Culture and Media. My JMP shows that when women grow up watching female empowered content on TV shows they are more likely to work as an adult ...*
>
> — *Javier Gonzalez*

Practice your interview skills early and often. My own abilities improved dramatically after 7th interview. The first few are where you make most mistakes, learn to control your nerves, and refine your answers. Ask your department to organize mock interviews with faculty, talk with seminar speakers when possible, and practice with peers who are also on the market. The American Society of Hispanic Economists (ASHE) sometimes offers mock interviews as well.

Concrete evidence of what you have already done is a far stronger signal than what you only plan to do. If you are already working on an idea, place it within your broader field, describe the progress to date (drafts, preliminary results, datasets, code, or presentations), and state the next steps and an approximate timeline. Highlight tangible outputs that committees can verify.

If you have teaching experience, summarize it concisely and with metrics: courses taught, level (undergraduate/graduate), enrollment, notable innovations (new syllabus, active-learning methods), and any evaluation scores or representative praise.

In interviews, confidently highlight and **brag** about your relevant accomplishments. If you have published papers, let them know by summarizing their main contribution; if you were an instructor with strong evaluations, cite specific metrics or examples. Use these accomplishments as concrete evidence of your ability to deliver.

When answering "Why our department/project/firm?" lead with personal reasons rather than only professional ones. Committees want to know you will be committed to living and working in their community. Briefly explain concrete personal motivations (for example, that you want to live in Europe rather than the U.S.) and add a concise reason to make the motivation believable and to complement the professional fit.

These are some of the examples I used:

- Family objectives (e.g. what do we want for our newborn daughter)
- Have *relatively close* family in the area
- Co-authors or alumni in your network are in the area

> *I want my newborn daugther to grow up immersed in the Latin American culture ... I also have two SMU alumni living in the city ...*
>
> — *Javier Gonzalez*

When they ask if you have any questions it has been recommended to Say that you don't have any, but if you do that you will reach out and comment on your exciment for the position.[7] I also tried to show that I did my research before the position:

- The videos introducing the department to undergraduate has good production value ...
- The research agenda of the postdoc is exciting because of ...

If you are in an industry or consulting interview, do ask questions I mainly asked about the specifics of the position or job in my interview with Analysis Group:

- What does a *Associate (Generalist)* mean?
- How much autonomy will I have to take cases?

[7] Recommended by Francisca Antman and David Schindler.

- Are there cases of new hires who failed to build up a reputation?

Regularly communicate with your advisor. they will know the best strategy to move forward. they will give you some advice on how to answer specific questions.

Send a thank you email a day after the interview. keep it short and sweet. if you made a mistake in the interview, you can use this opportunity to correct it (try to do this a couple hours after the interview). reiterate your exciment for the position

Waiting

At this point you will hear back from all postions you interviewed for and let you know if you are invited to fly-outs. They should typically let you know within 1-2 weeks after the interview.

Same advice applies as before, prioritize your mental health, get some work done if you can (it will make you feel productive), and **avoid** EconJobRumors at all cost.

Fly-outs

I got 2 fly-out invitations. One AP position in LATAM and one Postdoc in Australia. This ends up being a 40% conversion rate from interviews to fly-outs.[8]

Common Structure

For regular AP positions:

blah blah blah ...

Since COVID, some institutions have moved to a online fly-out, where you sit down on your computer and have 1-1 meetings with faculty and present your job market paper virtually.

Postdoc: No common structure here and will depends on the projects/team. In my case I had to present my JMP in 1 hour to the team (4 people).

Advice

Here there will be more logistic to take into consideration

Similar to the interviews, do not have your prefered place first. You gain experience and practice with each fly-out. Note however that sometimes the timing is not with you. That said do not chose a far away date, so that the committee does not think you want to fish for other opportunities

As soon as you get a fly-out invitation, tell your advisor. Politics now play a huge role and you want to send the best signals possible to maximize your offer chances. Your advisor will help you navigate this process.

I was suggested to always arrive a day before the fly-out invitation and hopefully morning or midday This is to not have time pressure if you miss a connection or flight. At the end the hotel will be payed for the night, so no need to save the department's money here.

Waiting

At this point you did all you can. That means that this will be the most stressful and emotional part of the market.

Prioritize your mental health.

As remember what my M.A. advisor told me:

> *All you need to have is one offer. When you get one, you know for sure that you will have a [job] next year.*
>
> — *Francisco Parro*

[8] This rate is similar to what McFall et. al. (2015) found.

Reflexions: What made my profile attractive?

Several concrete factors made my profile more attractive than it might have looked on paper. First, I was explicit about my willingness to relocate anywhere, which broadened the set of institutions that considered me seriously. I recognize this is a difficult ask for candidates with partners or families; being open to relocation is a signal that you will accept a wider variety of offers, but it also comes with real costs. If you are in a dual-career situation, seek out resources and advice on partner hiring and relocation support early, and communicate constraints clearly when appropriate.[9]

Second, my job-market profile emphasized a novel AI-based methodology applied to a traditional economics question. The timing, when many departments were actively exploring applied AI, meant committees were sometimes willing to take a chance on a candidate from a lower-ranked program if the work brought fresh tools and perspectives. Having clear, reproducible code, concise explanations of identification and robustness, and a one-paragraph elevator pitch about why the method matters for the substantive question helped reduce perceived risk and made the contribution easier to evaluate.

Finally, strong advocacy from my committee amplified these signals. My advisors actively promoted my work within their networks by making introductions, forwarding my CV, and flagging my job-market paper to colleagues who might be hiring. Those personal endorsements translated into more careful consideration from search committees and, in some cases, direct invites to interview. In combination, explicit geographic flexibility, a timely methodological edge, and proactive committee outreach materially improved how hiring committees perceived my candidacy.

[9] John Cawley's guide dicusses this in more detail.